Matthew D. Fails

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Academic Positions

Oakland University

Professor	2022 - present
Program Coordinator, Bachelor of Arts in International Relations	2016 - present
Associate Professor	2015 - 2022
Assistant Professor	2009 - 2015

Education

Ph.D. in Political Science, University of Missouri	2009
Bachelor of Arts in Political Science, Truman State University	2004

- *Magna cum laude*, Phi Beta Kappa

Research

Peer-Reviewed Research Articles

- Fails, Matthew D., and Taylor Richardson. 2025. "Economic Performance and the Type and Method of Presidential Term Limit Evasion." *Democratization 3*2 (8): 1949-1971. *(Co-author is an Oakland University undergraduate student)*.
- Fails, Matthew D. 2025. "Pain at the Pump, Pain at the Polls? Global Evidence on Election Timing, State Capacity, and Gasoline Prices." *Journal of Political Institutions and Political Economy* 6 (1): 1-25.
- Eldredge, Cody, and Matthew D. Fails. 2023. "When do Autocrats Create Sovereign Wealth Funds?" *Political Research Quarterly* 76 (2): 869-881.
- Fails, Matthew D. 2022. "What Types of Political Regimes Subsidize Fuel Consumption?" *The Extractive Industries and Society* 9:101037.
- Bellinger, Nisha, and Matthew D. Fails. 2021. "When Does Oil Harm Child Mortality?" *Political Research Quarterly* 74(3): 645-657.
- Fails, Matthew D. 2020. "Are Electoral Autocracies Better for the Poor? Evidence from Social Assistance Programs." *Research & Politics* 7(3): 1-7.
- Fails, Matthew D. 2020. "Oil Income and the Personalization of Autocratic Politics." *Political Science Research and Methods* 8(4): 772-779.
- Fails, Matthew D. 2019. "Fuel Subsidies Limit Democratization: Evidence from a Global Sample, 1990-2014." *International Studies Quarterly* 63 (2): 354-363.
- Carr, Douglass A., and Matthew D. Fails. 2018. "When Do Natural Resources Harm Fiscal Health? Evidence from the United States." *Politics & Policy* 46 (6): 878-911.
- Fails, Matthew D., and Marc D. DuBuis. 2015. "Resources, Rents Diversification, and the Collapse of Autocratic Regimes." *Political Research Quarterly* 68 (4): 703-715. *(Co-author is Oakland University undergraduate student)*
- Fails, Matthew D., and Byungwon Woo. 2015. "Unpacking Autocracy: Political Regimes and IMF Program Participation." *International Interactions* 41 (1):110–132.
- Fails, Matthew D. 2014. "Leader Turnover, Volatility, and Political Risk." *Politics & Policy* 42 (3): 369-399.

- Parke, Dana, and Matthew D. Fails. 2014. "The Logic of External Reform Resistance: Attitudes toward Economic and Political Liberalization in Senegal." *Journal of Developing Societies* 30(2): 145-167. *(Co-author is Oakland University undergraduate student)*
- Fails, Matthew D. 2012. "Inequality, Institutions, and the Risks to Foreign Investment." *International Studies Quarterly* 56 (3): 516-529.
- Fails, Matthew D., and Jonathan Krieckhaus. 2010. "Colonialism, Property Rights, and the Modern World Income Distribution." *British Journal of Political Science* 40 (3): 487-508.
- Fails, Matthew D., and Heather Nicole Pierce. 2010. "Changing Mass Attitudes and Democratic Deepening." *Political Research Quarterly* 63 (1): 174-187.
- Fails, Matthew D. 2009. "Does Substantive Democratization Create More Committed Democrats? Surprising Evidence from Africa." *Democratization* 16 (5): 841-866.

Editor-reviewed and Invited Essays

- Fails, Matthew D., and Jonathan Krieckhaus. 2014. "Colonialism and Democratization." *American Political Science Association – Comparative Democratization Newsletter* 12(1): 1, 3-6.

Book Reviews

- Fails, Matthew D. 2020. Review of *Power Grab: Political Survival through Extractive Resource Nationalization*, by Paasha Mahdavi. *Democratization* 28:3, 656-658, DOI: 10.1080/13510347.2020.1816967.
- Fails, Matthew D. 2011. Review of *Museveni's Uganda: Paradoxes of Power in a Hybrid Regime,* by Aili Marie Tripp. *Comparative Political Studies* 44(12): 1708-12.
- Fails, Matthew D. 2010. Review of *Turning Points in African Democracy,* eds. Abdul Raufa Mustapha and Lindsay Whitfield. *Democratization* 17 (5): 1059-61.

Conference Presentations

- "The Political Resource Curse in the Era of Democratic Backsliding: Evidence from Presidential Term Limit Evasions." Presented at the 2025 Michigan Political Science Association Annual Conference, October 2025, Detroit, MI.
- "Economic Performance and Presidential Term Limit Evasions," (co-authored with Taylor Richardson, Oakland University undergraduate). Presented at 2024 Annual Meeting of the Southern Political Science Association.
- "Autocratic Personalization and Sovereign Wealth Fund Creation." (co-authored with Cody Eldredge). Presented at 2021 Annual Meeting of the International Studies Association, April 2021.
- "Combatting Statistics Anxiety and Apathy through Service Learning and Community Engagement." Poster presented at Oakland University Community Engagement Town Hall, January 29, 2020.
- "Community Collaboration in Parks and Recreation Research" (co-authored with Sophie Marzolf [OU undergraduate] and Donna Folland). Presented at 2019 Southeastern Michigan Council of Governments Spring Meeting, May 5, 2019.
- "New Evidence on Authoritarianism and Fuel Subsidies." Presented at the Annual Meeting of the Southern Political Science Association, January 2019, Austin, TX.
- "The High Price of Cheap Gasoline." Presented at the 2017 Oakland University President's Colloquium. October 25, 2017, Oakland University, Rochester, MI.
- "The High Price of Cheap Gasoline: Fuel Subsidies and the Oil-Autocracy Connection." Presented at the Annual Meeting of the International Studies Association-Midwest, November 2016, St. Louis, MO.
- "Oil, Consumer Subsidies, and the Political Resource Curse." Presented at the Annual Meeting of the International Studies Association, March 2016, Atlanta, GA.

- "Resource Diversification and the Collapse of Autocracies." Talk delivered at Wayne State University Comparative Politics Colloquium, April 2015
- "Oil and the Political Resource Curse Presented at the Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association, April 2015, Chicago IL.
- "Power through the Pump: Oil Wealth, Consumer Subsidies, and Political Regimes." Co-authored with Kalsoom Hussain (Oakland University undergraduate student). Presented at the 2014 Michigan Political Science Association Conference, October 23-24, 2014, Rochester, MI.
- "Resource Diversification and the Durability of Autocratic Regimes." Co-authored with Marc DuBuis (Oakland University undergraduate student). Presented at the Annual Meeting of Midwest Political Science Association, April 2014, Chicago IL.
- "Structural Adjustment, Democracy, and Attitudes toward the West in Africa's New Democracies." Co-authored with Dana Parke (Oakland University undergraduate student). Presented at the Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association, April 2013, Chicago IL.
- "Political Replacement and Institutional Quality." Presented at the International Studies Association Annual Convention, April 2013, San Francisco, CA.
- "Authoritarian Varieties and IMF Program Participation." Co-authored with Byungwon Woo. Presented at the International Studies Association Annual Convention, April 2013, San Francisco, CA.
- "Dependency Theory, Colonialism, and the Making of the Modern World." Presented at the Oakland University Department of Political Science Research Forum, November 29, 2012.
- "The Colonial Foundations of Contemporary Wealth" Co-authored with Jonathan Krieckhaus. Presented at the Annual Meeting of the American Political Science Association, August 2011, Seattle, WA.
- "The Colonial Foundations of Contemporary Wealth." Co-authored with Jonathan Krieckhaus. Presented at the Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association, April 2011, Chicago, IL.
- "Inequality and Property Rights." Presented at the Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association, April 2010, Chicago IL.
- "Political Replacement and Property Rights." Presented at the Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association, April 2009, Chicago IL.
- "Democracy, Veto Players, and Property Rights." Presented at the Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association, April 2008, Chicago, IL.
- "Constitutive British Colonialism and the Modern World Income Distribution." Co-authored with Jonathan Krieckhaus. Presented at the Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association, April 2008, Chicago, IL.
- "A More Acceptable Game? Changing Mass Attitudes and Deepening Democracy." Co-authored with Heather Nicole Pierce. Presented at the Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association, April 2007, Chicago, IL.
- "State Capacity, Parochialism, and Support for Democracy in Africa." Presented at the Annual Meeting of the International Studies Association-Midwest, November 3-5, 2006, St. Louis, MO.
- "Colonial Contributions to Africa's Growth Tragedy." Presented at the Annual Meeting of the American Political Science Association, August 31-September 3, 2006, Philadelphia, PA.
- "Politics and Geography: Explaining African Economic Performance." Presented at the Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association, April 20-23, 2006, Chicago, IL.
- "Competing Colonial Explanations of Africa's Growth Tragedy." Presented at the Annual Meeting of the International Studies Association-Midwest, October 21-22, 2005, St. Louis, MO.

Courses Taught

- Comparative Politics
- Modern Dictatorships
- Data Analysis in Political Science
  - Including original service learning / experiential learning course in collaboration with Oakland County Parks and Recreation Department
- Senior Capstone in Comparative Politics (Special topic: "Making American Democracy Work (Better): Lessons from Comparative Politics")
- Senior Capstone in Comparative Politics (Special topic: "Blood Diamonds and Petro-Politics: The Resource Curse in Comparative Perspective")
- Honors College 2070 (Is Democracy Dying?)
- Honors College 206 ("Bad Guys, Tyrants, and Emperors: Dictators and the Societies they Govern")
- The Politics of Development
- African Politics
- Introduction to Africa (International Studies Program)

Administrative and Leadership Experience at Oakland University (selected)

- Program Coordinator, International Relations 2016-present
  - Faculty lead for the Department of Political Science's three Bachelor of Arts in International Relations degrees (B.A. in International Relations, B.A. in International Relations with Specialization in Foreign Affairs and Diplomacy, B.A. in International Relations with Specialization in Global Justice and Sustainability)
  - Responsible for all program assessment and annual reporting, including permanent position on department's Undergraduate Curriculum and Assessment Committee
  - Cultivated internship and study abroad opportunities with local and national organizations and programs
  - Coordinated with other departments to align curriculum goals, course offerings, catalog changes, and other curriculum and program goals to enhance interdisciplinary vision of International Relations program
  - Represent the program at various on and off-campus events, especially those focused on community engagement and student recruitment
  - Examine transfer credit requests, and process various department and College of Arts and Sciences petitions of exception
  - Serve as centralized advisor for undergraduate majors
- Founder, *Political Science Research Symposium* (2010-present)
  - Institutionalized the department's growing emphasis on undergraduate research and student success by providing various forums and mentoring opportunities, including:
    - Facilitating the presentation of original research by more more than one hundred undergraduate students in annual poster sessions
    - Organizing more than thirty research presentations from faculty, students, and visiting scholars

    * Personally mentoring more than thirty undergraduate student original research projects for presentation at various national and local research conferences, including the *International Studies Association-Midwest* (2021), *Pi Sigma Alpha National Undergraduate Conference* (2017 – present), *Midwest Political Science Association* (2013-2015), the *Michigan Political Science Association Conference* (2014, 2025), and the Meeting of the Minds Undergraduate Research Conference (2013), and 23 (and counting) Honors College Thesis Projects

- University Research Committee, Chair (2021-2022) Member (2020-2021)
    * Chaired interdisciplinary committee of members from all academic units on campus and allocated more than $300,000 across numerous competitive internal funding opportunities
- Honors College Council, Member (2016-2019)
- College of Arts and Sciences Community Engagement Taskforce, Policy group (2019-2021)
- Member, University Faculty Senate (2026, 2027)
- Member, College of Arts and Sciences Assembly (2010, 2023-present)
- Member, College of Arts and Sciences Dean's Budgetary Advisory Committee (2022-2024)
- Co-Chair and Member (2010-2013, 2018-present) of Department of Political Science Undergraduate Curriculum and Assessment Committee
- Chair (2021, 2020) and Member (2016, 2017, 2018) of Department of Political Science Merit Committee
- Chair (2012) of Working Group on Capstone Assessment
- Political Science Personnel Committee Chair (2014, 2016) and Member (2010, 2011)
- Political Science Candidate Review Committee Chair and/or Member (2016, 2017, 2018, 2021, 2023)
    - Chaired or served on committees for pre-tenure, tenure, and promotion to full reviews for numerous faculty colleagues

Grants, Awards, and Honors (selected)

- Provost's AI Integration Grant for Agentic Applications in undergraduate Data Analysis course (Winter 2027)
- University Research Committee Faculty Fellowship for "Identifying Executive Term Limit Violations and the Consequences for Democratic Survival," Summer 2024 (grant successfully funded for $10,000, including money for undergraduate RA)
- Delivered the President's Colloquium titled "The High Cost of Cheap Gasoline" (October 25, 2017).
- University Research Committee Faculty Fellowship for "The Curse of Oil: Why Cheap Gas is Good for Dictators but Bad for Citizens, the Economy, and the Environment," Summer 2015 (grant successfully funded for $10,000).
- College of Arts and Sciences Order of the Plume
- Honors College Inspiration Award (2013)
- Honors College Summer Experience Featured Professor (2015)
- Honors College Council Member
- Dean of the College of Arts and Sciences Student Success Initiative ($1500 for student travel to conferences in 2014 and 2015)
- Department of Political Science Meritorious Research Award (2013-14)
- Department of Political Science Meritorious Service Award (2013-14)

- e-Lis Development Grant for development of online version of course PS 131: Comparative Politics (grant successfully funded for $3,000)
- University Research Committee Faculty Fellowship for "Colonialism and Long-Run Development," Summer 2011 (grant successfully funded for $9,000)
- College of Arts and Sciences Marion P. Wilson Award for Excellence in Faculty Research ($500; awarded for "Colonialism, Property Rights, and the Modern World Income Distribution"), Fall 2011
- College of Arts and Sciences *Celebrating the Liberal Arts* Funded Proposal for "Whose Borders Are They? The Case Against the African State," 2010 (proposal funded for $2,500)

Disciplinary and Professional Service (selected)

- *Council on Undergraduate Research*, Social Science Division Representative (2024-2027)
- Manuscript review (selected list): *American Political Science Review, American Journal of Political Science, Journal of Politics, International Studies Quarterly, Comparative Political Studies, Comparative Politics, Global Studies Quarterly, World Development, International Political Science Review, Political Research Quarterly, Foreign Policy Analysis, Political Research and Methods, International Interactions, Democratization, Studies in Comparative International Development, Oxford University Press*
- Chair / Panel Discussant at *International Studies Association Annual Convention* (2013)
- Chair / Panel Discussant at *Midwest Political Science Association* Annual Meeting (2010, 2011, 2014, 2016)
- Chair / Panel Discussant at *Southern Political Science Association* Annual Meeting (2016)
- PhD Committee Member, Derwin Munroe (Wayne State University, defended 2024)

References

Graeme Harper, Ph.D.
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